

CENTRAL AND SOUTH AMERICA

CENTRAL AMERICA IS A NARROW BRIDGE of land linking Mexico in the north to South America in the south. A string of mountains runs down its length, capped by volcanoes. The beautiful, palm-fringed islands of the Caribbean Sea lie off its east coast. South America, the fourth largest continent, contains a range of very different landscapes. About 60 percent of the continent is covered in vast, grassy plains. The towering Andes Mountains stretch along the west coast, with the long, thin Atacama Desert sandwiched between the mountains and the sea. Tropical rain forests spread in a lush green blanket across huge areas of the northeast.



THE AMAZON RIVER

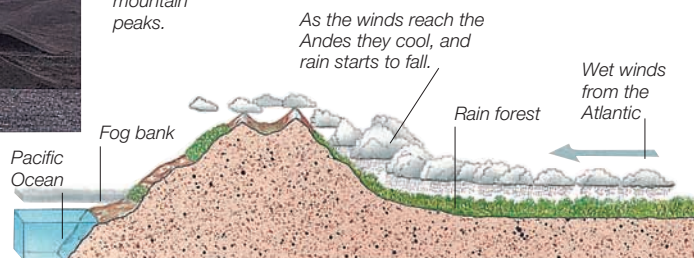
The world's largest rain forest grows in the vast basin of the mighty Amazon, the longest river in South America. The Amazon rises high in the snowcapped Andes in Peru, then flows 4,001 miles (6,439 km) across Peru and Brazil to its mouth in the Atlantic Ocean. The Amazon carries more water than any other river. At its mouth the Amazon is so wide that you cannot see from one bank to the other. The river discharges so much water into the ocean that the water is still brackish 112 miles (180 km) out to sea.



The Andean condor has a wingspan of 10 ft (3 m). Its huge wings help it soar above mountain peaks.

THE ANDES

Stretching for 4,505 miles (7,250 km) along the entire length of South America, the Andes are the world's longest mountain range. Many peaks rise above 19,685 ft (6,000 m). The mountains were formed when two plates of the Earth's crust collided. The plates are still moving, causing numerous earthquakes and volcanoes along the range. An extinct volcano, Aconcagua, is the highest Andean peak and the highest mountain in South America at 22,835 ft (6,960 m). The world's highest navigable lake, Titicaca, lies in the Andes between Peru and Bolivia.



Very little rain falls on the western side of the Andes, which is mostly desert.

THE ANDES AND CLIMATE

The Andes have a major effect on the weather of South America. Warm, wet winds from the Atlantic rise up the eastern slopes. As they rise, they cool and the water in them falls as rain. On the dry, western slopes, the weather conditions are completely different. Here the winds pass over the cold Humboldt Current as they blow in off the sea. This causes them to cool and form a fog bank.

Patagonia covers about 270,272 sq miles (700,000 sq km) of southern Chile and Argentina.



PATAGONIA

In the far southeast of South America lies a huge, dry, windswept plateau of land called Patagonia. This region is sparsely populated, but some small groups of sheep farmers live near Colorado and Negro rivers. They include a community of Welsh-speakers whose ancestors settled in the region during the 1860s. Northern Patagonia is semidesert with some scrubby vegetation. The south is colder, drier, and bleaker, with very little plant life.



THE PAMPAS

Rolling grasslands cover the center of Argentina and extend into neighboring Paraguay. These are the pampas, vast open plains that stretch across an area of 250,967 sq miles (650,000 sq km). The western pampas are dry, semidesert, but the eastern part has frequent rainfall. The pampas form the economic heartland of Argentina. Large herds of beef cattle are grazed on the plains. Other areas have been plowed up to grow huge amounts of wheat, corn, beans, and other crops.